POLITICAL COMMUNICATION DURING CRISIS

Norwegian Politicians on Facebook

The First COVID-19 Lockdown Period · March–May 2020

· 580 posts · 11 political actors

Context & Purpose

01

Bounded crisis window

March 12 – May 12, 2020 captures the first Norwegian lockdown: a period of high public attention, rapid institutional response, and elevated communication volume.

02

Political actor focus

Data restricted to Norwegian politician pages administered from Norway. Organisations, media pages, and other page types were excluded for analytical clarity.

03

Descriptive & associative

The models are used as descriptive association tools, not causal inference. Wording throughout stays with 'associated with' and 'linked to' rather than causal language.

Data & Methods

580	11	62 days	1,165
Total posts analysed	Political actors	Analytic window	Mean interactions per post

Analytical pipeline

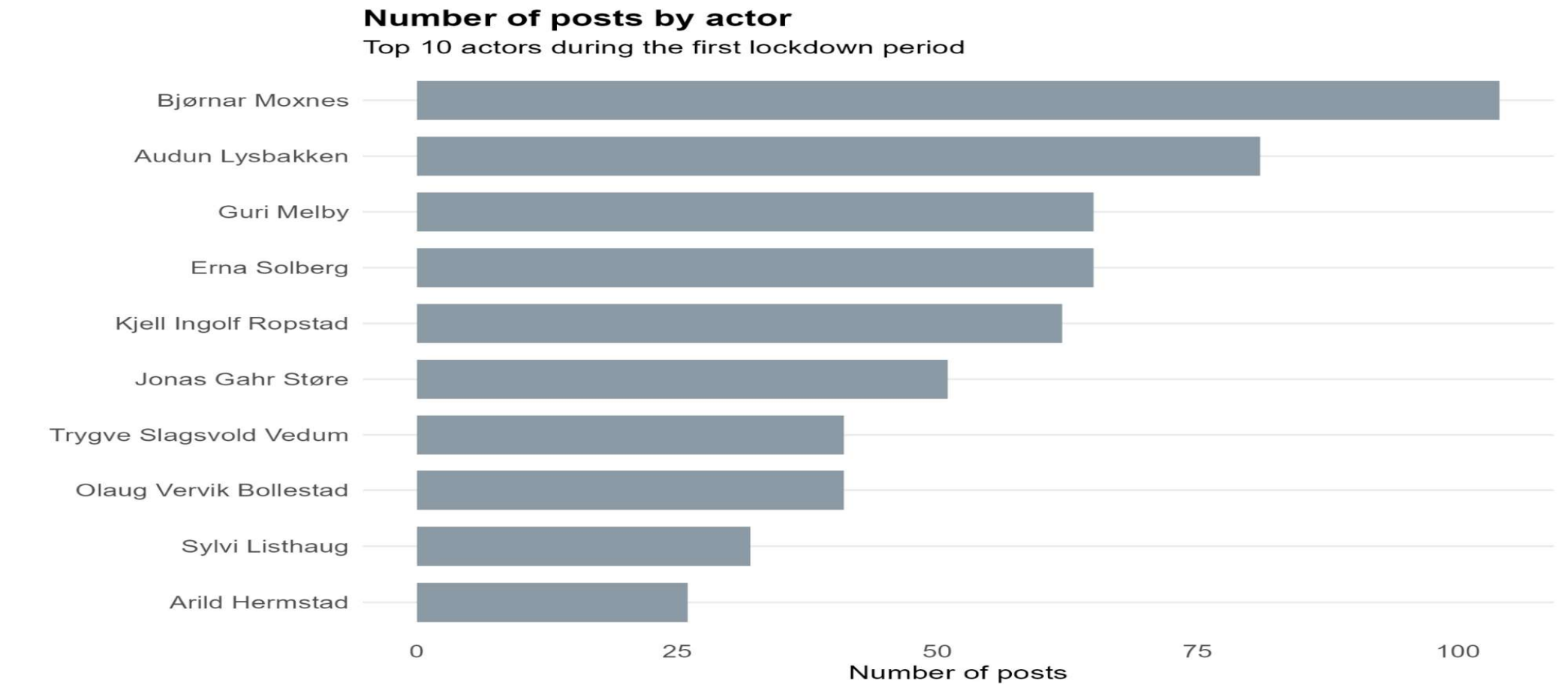
1. Facebook export → clean & restrict to Norwegian politician pages
2. Derive variables: post type, log interactions, weekday, COVID keyword
3. Apply hand-coded strategy variables (9 categories) from doctoral coding
4. Descriptive summaries → Linear OLS (log interactions) → Negative binomial model

Note on skew

Mean (1,165) vs. median (498) reveals a strongly right-skewed distribution which is typical for engagement data. Both a linear OLS and a negative binomial model were estimated.

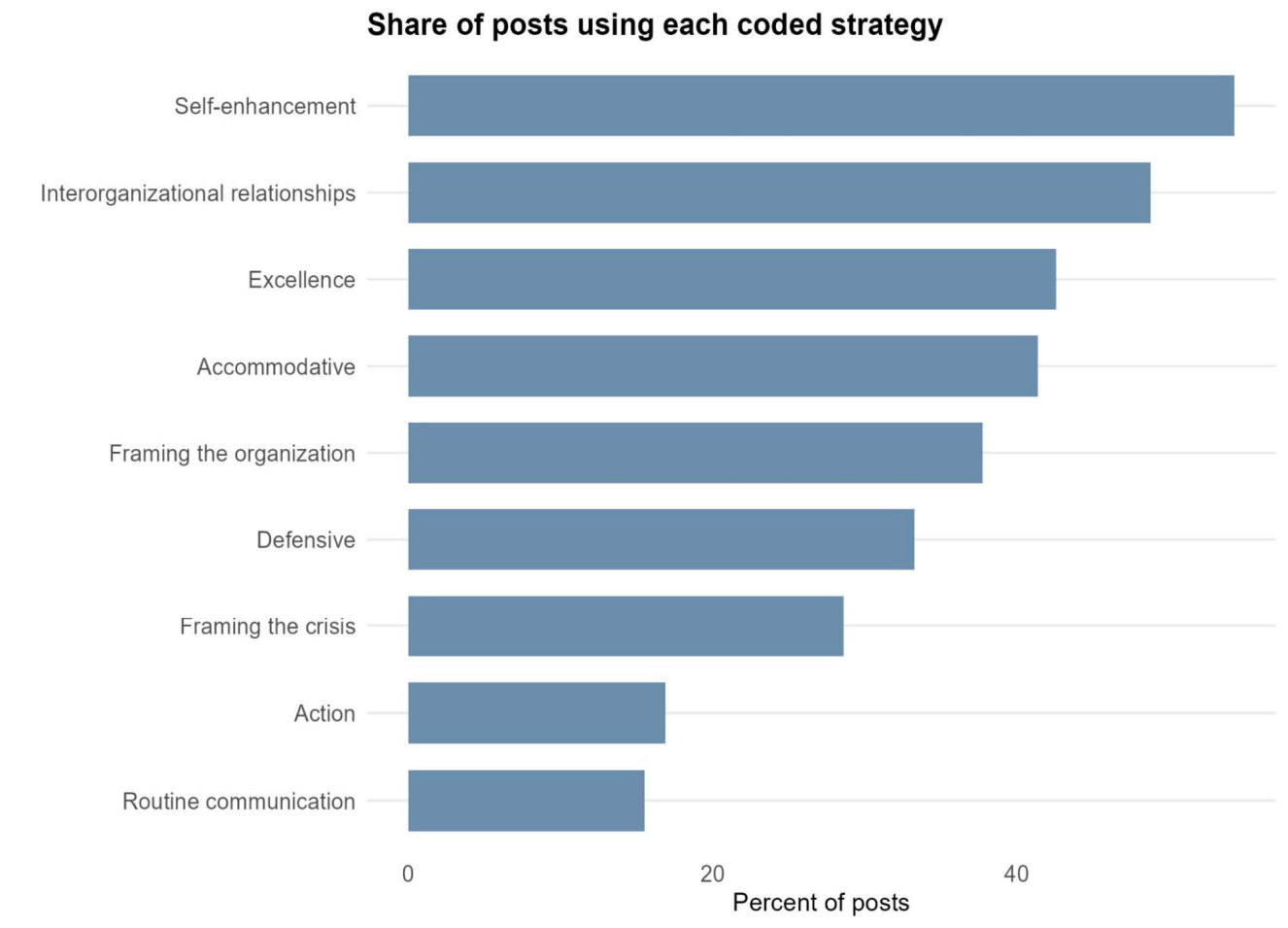
Who Posted Most?

Number of posts by actor during the first lockdown period



Communication Strategies

Share of posts using each coded strategy (nine categories)



Key findings

54%
Self-enhancement — the most common coded strategy

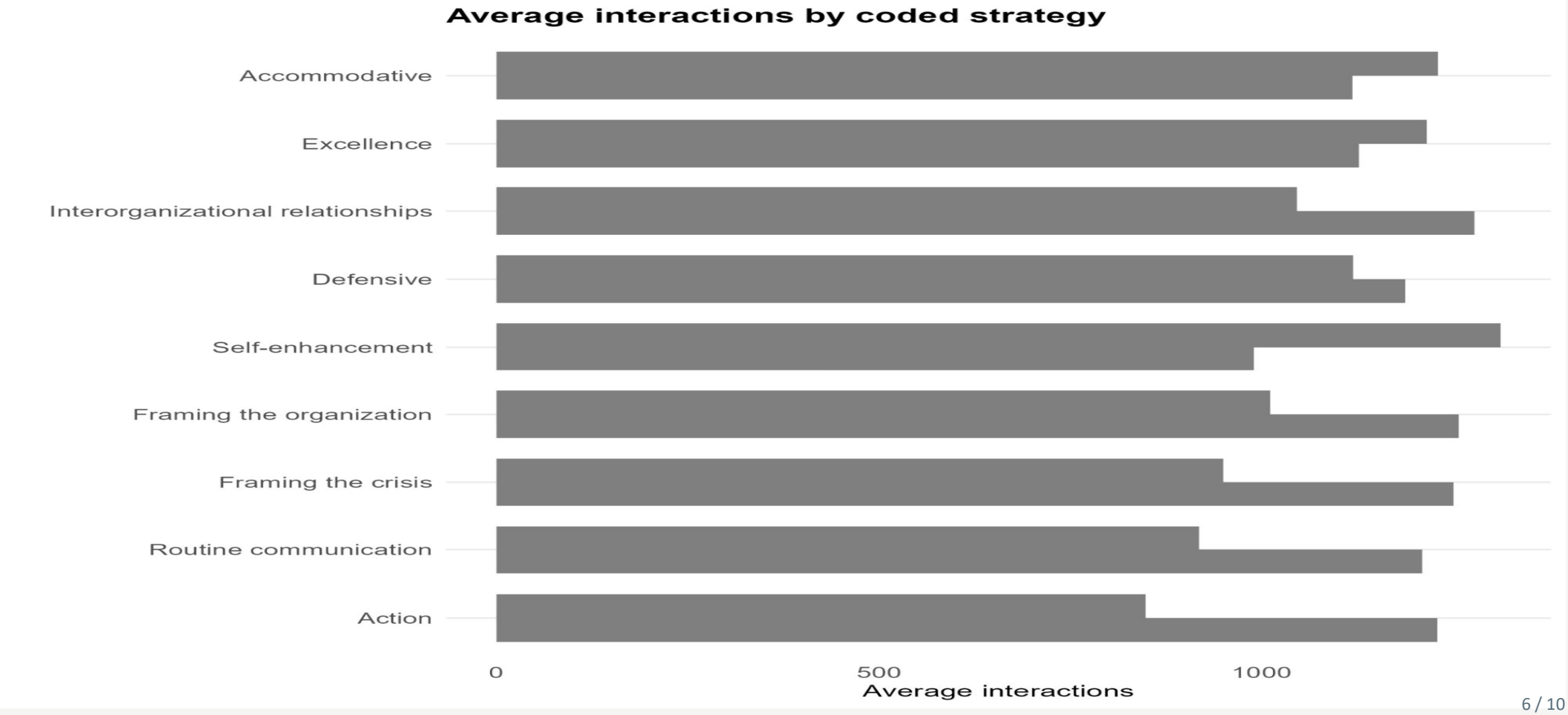
49%
Interorganizational relationships ranked second

42%
Excellence appeared in roughly 4 in 10 posts

15%
Routine communication least frequent

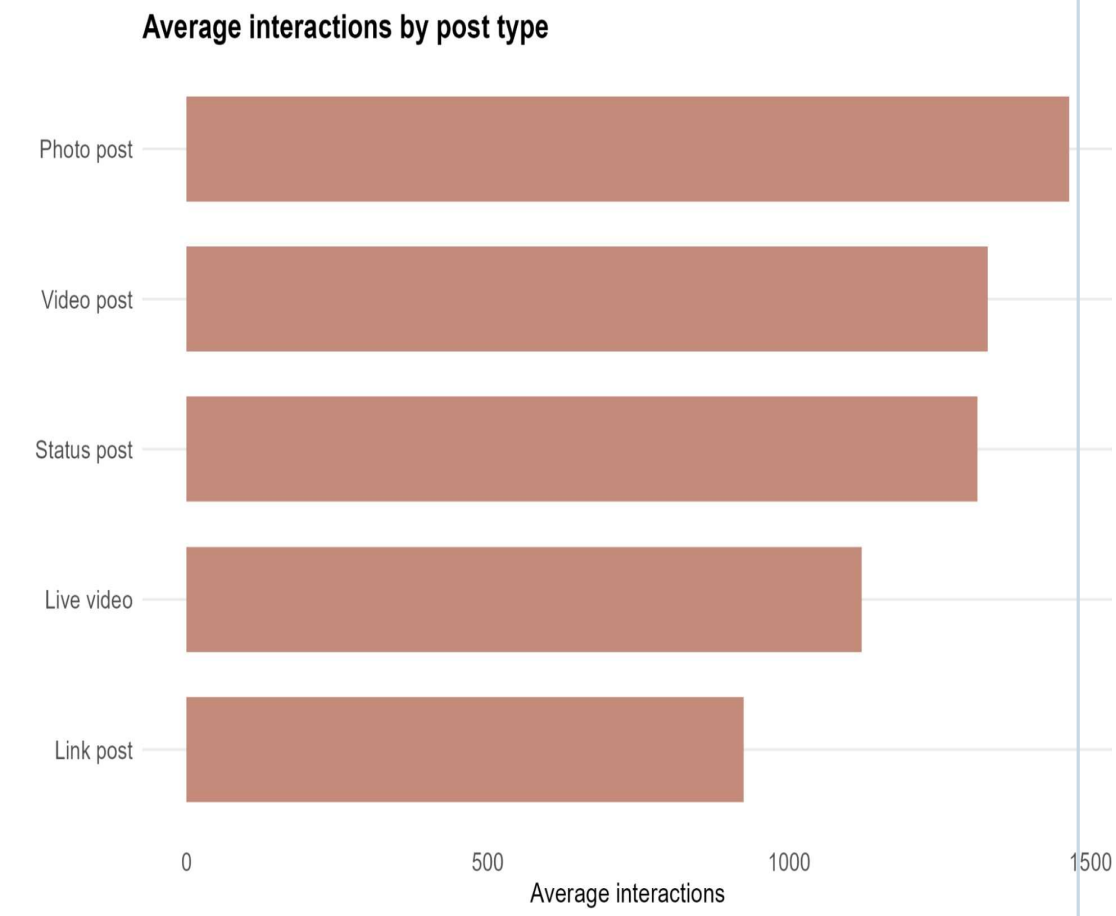
Strategy & Engagement

Average interactions by coded strategy — dark bars show when present, lighter bars when absent

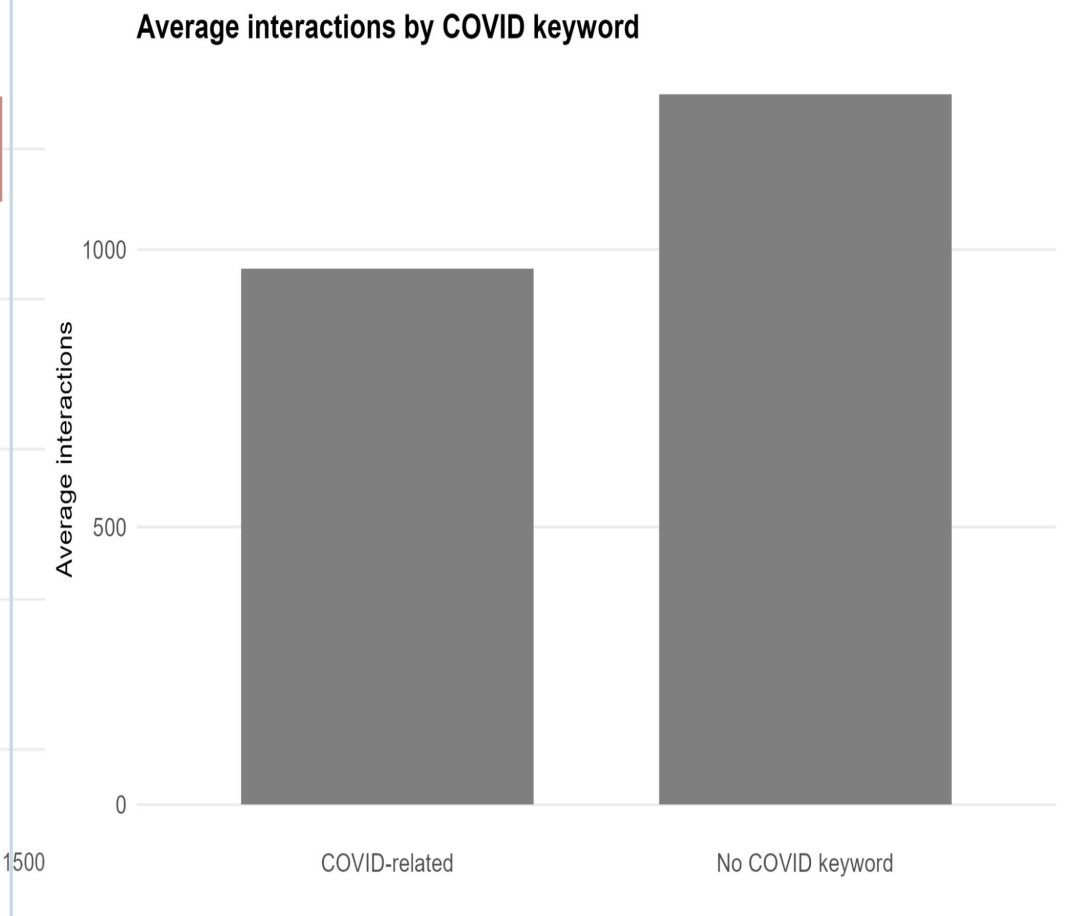


Post Format & COVID Keyword

Average interactions by post type

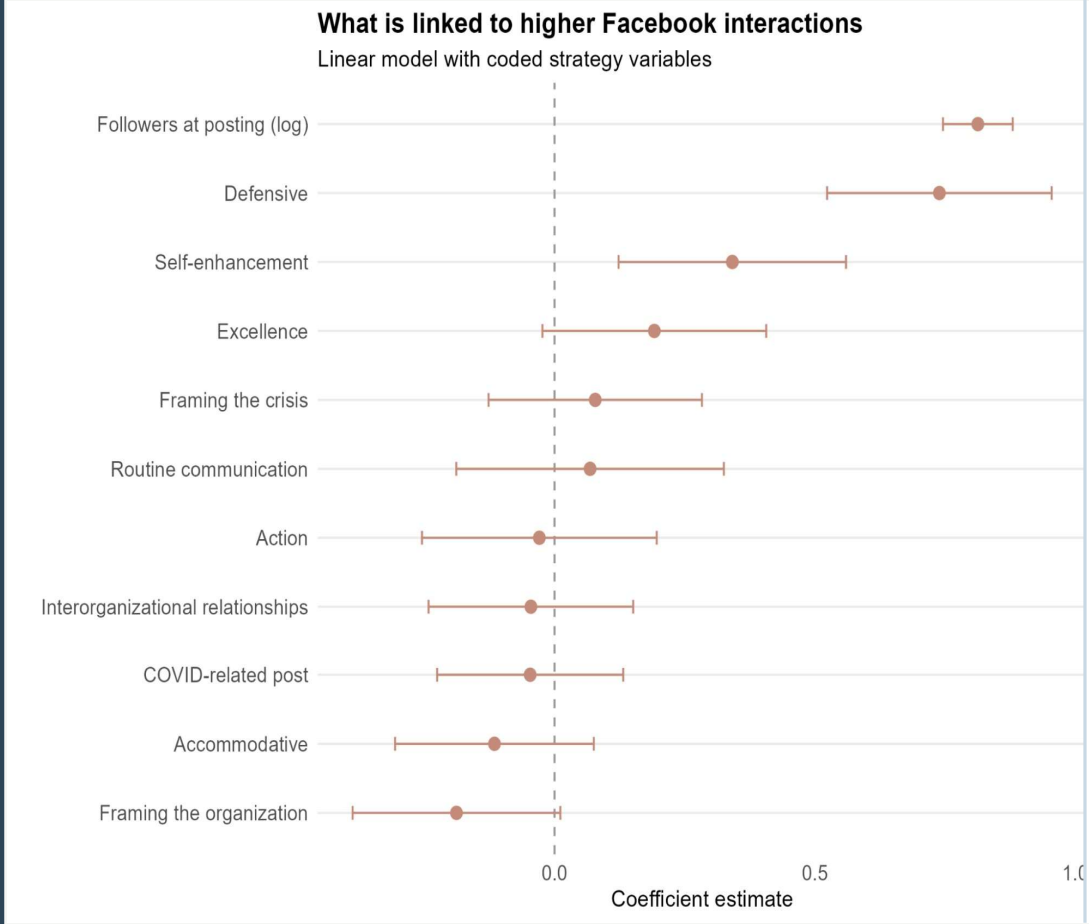


Average interactions by COVID keyword presence

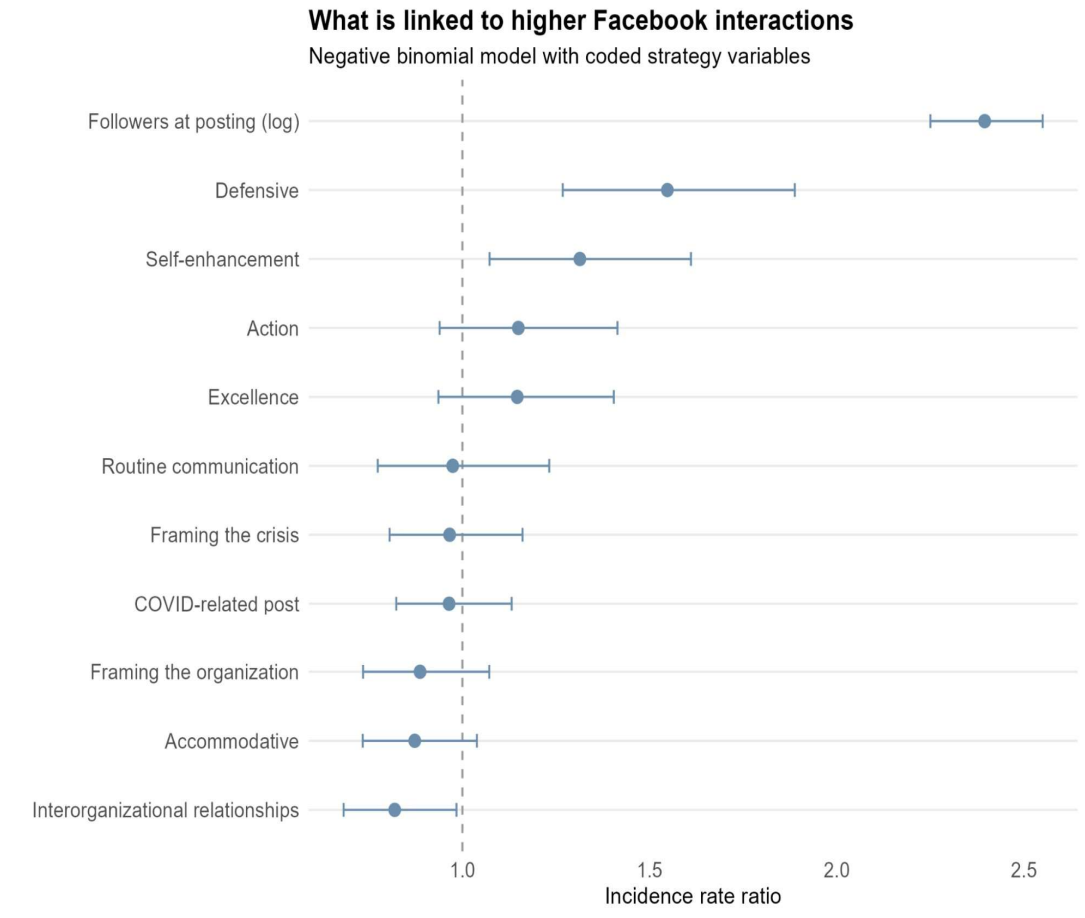


Regression Models

Linear model (log interactions)



Negative binomial model (count)



Key Takeaways

1

Follower size dominates

Across both model specifications, the logged follower count at time of posting was by far the strongest predictor of interaction levels — audience size matters most.

2

Defensive & self-enhancement strategies outperform

Both strategies were clearly associated with higher interactions. In the negative binomial model, defensive communication showed an incidence rate ratio well above 1.0.

3

Photo posts perform best

Photo posts averaged ~1,450 interactions, and the negative binomial model estimated an IRR of approximately 1.90 relative to the reference category — format matters.

4

COVID keyword ≠ more engagement

Posts without a COVID keyword averaged higher interactions than COVID-tagged posts. Mentioning the crisis was not itself a driver of reach in this bounded period.

Selected References

- Diaz et al. (2016). Online and social media data as an imperfect continuous panel survey. PLOS ONE, 11(1).
- Fiskvik, Bjarko & Ihlen (2023). Trustworthiness over time on Twitter: Three critical periods during COVID-19. Social Media + Society, 9(2).
- Jacobsen & Larsson (2024). Business as usual? Assessing amplified political posts across platforms during COVID-19. Social Media + Society, 10(4).

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